came to be regulated by English laws implemented by English administrators, who were implicitly considered more civilized than those they ruled over. But as Indians across the subcontinent became empowered by education in the twentieth century, they began to challenge Britain's right to rule.

The Indian National Congress came into being in 1885, marking the beginning of a sustained effort, by the Congress and others, to demand representation in government, equality under the law and, later on, full independence for Indians. In different ways and at different times, scores of Indians wrote, argued, protested, lobbied, assassinated, marched, went to prison and died for their belief in India's right to be an independent nation. In a way, every one of them helped build modern India.

This section focuses on five key figures within the movement for independence, each of whom had strong views on how India could become independent and what that independent nation should be like.